

A close-up photograph of several stacks of poker chips in red, green, and black with white patterns, resting on a green felt surface. In the foreground, several playing cards are fanned out, showing the King of Diamonds, Jack of Diamonds, Ten of Diamonds, and Ace of Diamonds. A semi-transparent green rectangular box is overlaid on the bottom half of the image, containing the title and author information.

Poker Cheat Sheet

INSPIRED BY MIKKI MASE



Poker Hand Rankings

ROYAL FLUSH

- ♠ The absolute best hand in poker. Comprises A-K-Q-J-10, all in the same suit.
- ♦ Extremely rare, and guarantees victory in a showdown.

Strategic Insight: Due to its rarity, playing in anticipation of completing a Royal Flush is not a viable strategy.

STRAIGHT FLUSH

- ♣ Any five sequential cards of the same suit, e.g., 9-8-7-6-5 of hearts.
- ♥ The second-best possible hand in poker.
- ♠ The highest straight flush, A-K-Q-J-10, is a Royal Flush.

Strategic Insight: A powerhouse hand, often unbeatable. Bet and raise for value, but remain observant of possible better hands (higher straight flushes or Royal Flush on a paired board could mean facing a full house).

FOUR OF A KIND (QUADS)

- ♦ Four cards of the same rank, e.g., four Aces.
- ♣ Extremely strong hand, rarely beaten.

Strategic Insight: Play for maximum value; slow play or trap if the board is non-threatening. Be cautious on boards with potential straight flushes.

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FULL HOUSE

- ♦ A combination of three of a kind and a pair, e.g., three 7s and two Kings.
- ♣ Very strong hand, but can be beaten by quads or a higher full house.

Strategic Insight: Evaluate the board carefully. Against aggressive betting, consider the possibility of facing higher full houses.

FLUSH

- ♥ Five cards of the same suit, not in sequential order, e.g., A-J-9-5-2 of clubs.
- ♠ Strong, but can be beaten by a higher flush or above.

Strategic Insight: Play aggressively but be mindful of higher flush possibilities especially if you hold a lower flush.

STRAIGHT

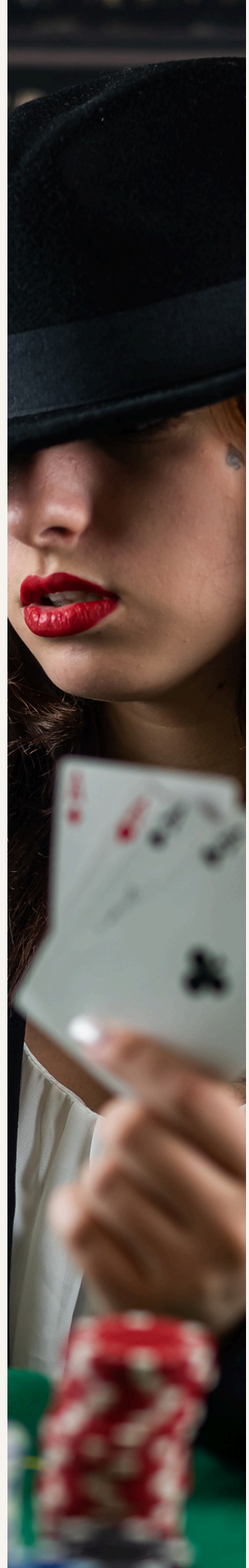
- ♦ Five sequential cards of different suits, e.g., 6-7-8-9-10.
- ♣ Can lose to flushes, full houses, and higher straights.

Strategic Insight: Value bet, but proceed with caution if the board pairs or there are flush draws.

THREE OF A KIND

- ♥ Three cards of the same rank, e.g., three Queens.
- ♠ Solid hand, but vulnerable to straights, flushes, and higher sets.

Strategic Insight: Best played in pots with fewer players. Consider the likelihood of opponents completing higher hands.



TWO PAIR

- ♦ Two different pairs, e.g., two 8s and two 4s.
- ♣ Decent hand, but can be outdrawn easily.

Strategic Insight: Value bet in unraised pots, but be wary of action from stronger hands.

ONE PAIR

- ♥ Two cards of the same rank, e.g., two Aces.
- ♠ Common and often in play. Strength greatly depends on the pair's rank and board texture.

Strategic Insight: Play for maximum value; slow play or trap if the board is non-threatening. Be cautious on boards with potential straight flushes.

HIGH CARD

- ♦ When you don't form any of the above hands, the highest card in your hand is your "high card".
- ♣ The weakest hand in poker.

Strategic Insight: Rarely wins at showdown in contested pots. Often, the best play is to fold, unless bluffing in unchallenged pots.

Pot Odds & Expected Value Expanded:

POT ODDS:

FORMULA: POT ODDS = POT SIZE / CALL COST



Decision-making: If the pot odds are higher than the odds of completing your hand, calling becomes profitable in the long run. It's a measure of risk vs. reward.

EXPECTED VALUE

EV FORMULA: $EV = (\text{WINNING PROBABILITY} * \text{POT SIZE}) - (\text{LOSING PROBABILITY} * \text{CALL SIZE})$.

POSITIVE EV (+EV) INDICATES A PROFITABLE PLAY OVER TIME, WHILE NEGATIVE EV (-EV) SUGGESTS A LOSING PROPOSITION. ALWAYS AIM FOR +EV DECISIONS.

Include considerations like implied odds (future bets you might win if you hit your hand) and reverse implied odds (losses you might face even if you hit your hand but it's not the best).

Pot Odds & Expected Value Expanded:

STRONG HANDS

- ☒ Strategy: Raise and re-raise to isolate or play heads-up. Avoid giving free/cheap cards to potentially outdraw you.
- ☒ Positional flexibility allows for a wider range of actions, including raising for value and applying pressure on limpers or weaker ranges.

GOOD HANDS

- ☒ Adapt based on table dynamics. In aggressive tables, consider tightening up and vice versa.
- ☒ Utilize these hands to balance your range by occasionally mixing up play styles (e.g., slow-playing AA or KK pre-flop in very specific scenarios).

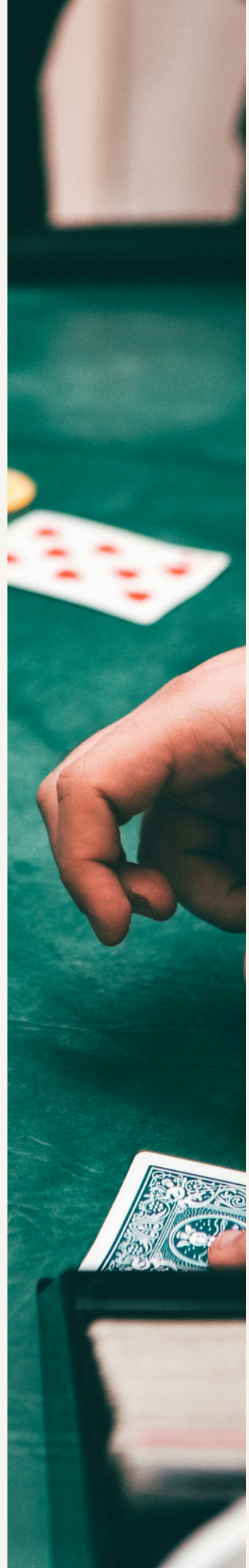
MARGINAL HANDS

- ☒ Suited Connectors & Low Pairs: Ideal for speculative play, looking for opportunities to hit disguised strong hands like straights, flushes, or sets.
- ☒ Play these hands with caution, especially in early positions. Consider fold equity and stack sizes when deciding to enter a pot.

Post-Flop Strategy Detailed:

TOP PAIR

- ☒ Assess kicker strength and board texture. A top pair with a weak kicker can be vulnerable.
- ☒ Consider the number of players in the hand; fewer players mean your top pair holds more value.





OVERCARDS

- ✓ Context is key. Overcards with a backdoor flush or straight potential can be more playable.
- ✓ Assess opponent tendencies. Against tight players, your overcards might still be ahead; against aggressive players, caution is warranted.

FLUSH/STRAIGHT DRAWS

- ✓ Distinguish between open-ended straight draws (OESD) and gutshot straight draws. OESD are more valuable.
- ✓ For flush draws, consider the nut flush draw (using the Ace) versus lower flush draws. Nut flush draws offer potential for aggressive play.

SET MINING

- ✓ Ideal with deep stacks where hitting a set can lead to winning a substantial pot.
- ✓ Pay attention to your opponents' tendencies. Set mining against aggressive players who bet and raise a lot can be very profitable.

ADDITIONAL CONSIDERATIONS

- ✓ Always adjust your strategy based on the specific dynamics of the table and the tendencies of your opponents.
- ✓ Continuously assess the effective stack sizes when making pre-flop and post-flop decisions. Stack size influences the playability of hands significantly, affecting both your strategy and the range of hands you should play.

Bluffing & Reading Opponents:

BLUFFING

- ✓ Most effective in tight situations, ideally against a single opponent or at most two.
- ✓ Choose moments when the community cards enhance the believability of your supposed hand.
- ✓ Consider your table image; bluffing works better if you've been playing tight and showing down strong hands.
- ✓ Semi-bluffing, where you bluff but still have a drawing hand, can be a powerful strategy.

READING OPPONENTS

- ✓ **Bet Sizing:** Larger bets often signal strong hands; smaller bets might indicate a draw or a weaker hand trying to see a cheap river.
- ✓ **Timing Tells:** Quick bets or raises can suggest strength, while hesitation may indicate a decision on bluffing or the value of a marginal hand.
- ✓ **Physical Tells:** Though less reliable online, in live games, changes in posture, facial expressions, and hand movements can reveal insights into a player's comfort level with their hand.
- ✓ **Player Tendencies:** Categorize opponents as tight, loose, aggressive, or passive to predict their possible actions and hand ranges.

Bankroll Management:

CASH GAMES



A minimum of 20-30 buy-ins for the level you're playing is essential to cushion against swings and variance.



Adjust your game selection based on your bankroll's health. Dropping down stakes during a downswing is a strategic move to preserve your bankroll.

TOURNAMENTS



Tournaments typically have higher variance than cash games, hence the recommendation for 50-100 buy-ins.



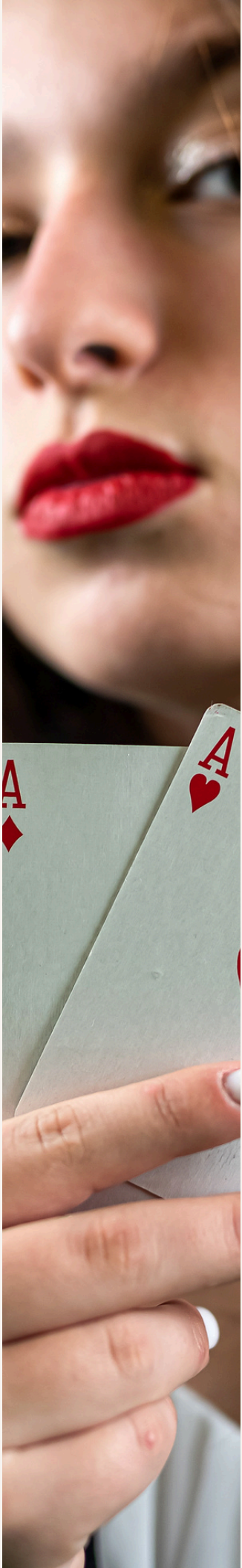
Consider the type of tournaments you're entering (large field vs. small field, turbo vs. deep stack) as this impacts variance.

Playing Styles:

TIGHT-AGGRESSIVE (TAG)

- ✓ Selective with starting hands but aggressive with bets and raises when entering a pot, maximizing the value from strong hands.
- ✓ Dominates in most poker formats due to its balance of patience and assertiveness.





LOOSE-AGGRESSIVE (LAG)

- ☒ Plays a wide range of hands and uses aggression to take down pots and put opponents under pressure.
- ☒ Requires deep understanding of post-flop play, opponents' tendencies, and adaptability.

TIGHT-PASSIVE (ROCK)

- ☒ Plays a very narrow range of hands and tends to call rather than bet or raise.
- ☒ Predictable and often exploited by more aggressive players.

LOOSE-PASSIVE (CALLING STATION)

- ☒ Enters many pots but rarely takes the initiative, leading to bleeding chips in the long run.
- ☒ Exploitable by betting for value with strong hands.

Positional Play:

EARLY POSITION (EP)

- ☒ Being first to act post-flop, you're at a significant informational disadvantage. Play only the strongest hands.

MIDDLE POSITION (MP)

- ☒ As the table dynamics begin to unfold, you can start to widen your range slightly, though caution is still advised.

LATE POSITION (LP) & BUTTON

- ☒ Holding the most information as you're the last to act, you can afford to play a wider range of hands.
- ☒ Use this position to leverage your bets, steals, and bluffs.



Playing Styles:

FOLD EQUITY

- ☑ The expected value gained from forcing an opponent to fold. It increases with the aggressiveness of the play and the susceptibility of opponents to fold.

TABLE IMAGE

- ☑ The perception opponents have of your playing style. An aggressive image might lead opponents to fold more readily against your bets; a passive image might encourage opponents to bluff into you.

STACK-TO-POT RATIO (SPR)

- ☑ A measure of how many times the pot size could be covered by the remaining effective stacks. Lower SPRs lead to more committed pots, influencing the range of hands you should play.



Additional Tips:

- ☑ **Strategic Adaptability:** Be ready to shift your strategy based on the current table dynamics, game flow, and the adjustment of your opponents.
- ☑ **Continual Learning:** Poker is a game of skill and strategy that evolves. Staying updated on strategies and analyzing your play can lead to sustained improvement.
- ☑ **Mental Discipline:** Emotional control is crucial. Recognize when you're on tilt and take breaks to maintain optimal decision-making. Prioritize physical and mental health to support your poker performance.

